Homework 3.1 – Network Traffic Analysis with Zeek

CS 6349 Network Security · Amna Tahir · Worked solution · PCAP: `2023-07-25-IcedID-infection-traffic-1.pcap` (8,604 packets, 2023-07-25 16:34:56 – 20:21:46 UTC) · Zeek 7.0.11 LTS

Part 1 – Getting started with Zeek

The pcap was unzipped with the password `infected_20230725`. Only the `.pcap` was analyzed; no other file was extracted or run. Zeek was run in an empty folder twice: once for tab-separated logs and once for JSON logs.

```
$ zeek --version
zeek version 7.0.11
$ zeek -r 2023-07-25-IcedID-infection-traffic-1.pcap                          # TSV logs
$ zeek -r 2023-07-25-IcedID-infection-traffic-1.pcap LogAscii::use_json=T     # JSON logs (separate folder)
$ ls *.log
analyzer.log conn.log dns.log files.log http.log ntp.log ocsp.log packet_filter.log ssl.log x509.log
```

Log	Records	Log	Records
conn.log	506	x509.log	31
dns.log	310	files.log	11
ssl.log	110	analyzer.log	2 (protocol violations)
http.log	6	notice.log / weird.log	not created (0 events)

`zeek-cut` was used to read the TSV logs and `jq` for the JSON logs (examples in each answer). All times are UTC.

```
$ zeek --version
zeek version 7.0.11
$ zeek -r 2023-07-25-IcedID-infection-traffic-1.pcap
$ ls *.log
analyzer.log conn.log dns.log files.log http.log ntp.log ocsp.log packet_filter.log ssl.log x509.log
$ zeek-cut proto < conn.log | sort | uniq -c
    121 tcp
    385 udp
$ zeek-cut service < conn.log | sort | uniq -c | sort -rn
    329 dns
    110 ssl
     61 -
      5 http
      1 ntp
$ zeek-cut id.resp_h < conn.log | grep -vE "^(10\.|192\.168\.|224\.|239\.)" | sort | uniq -c | sort -rn | head -4
     53 2.56.177.122
      8 140.99.221.138
      4 52.137.108.250
      4 204.79.197.200
$ zeek-cut -d ts id.orig_h id.resp_h host uri status_code resp_mime_types response_body_len < http.log | head -3 | cut -
c1-150
2023-07-25T16:34:56+0000        10.7.25.101     173.232.146.10  173.232.146.10  /       302     -       0
2023-07-25T16:38:09+0000        10.7.25.101     128.199.3.164   filtaferamoza.com       /       200     application/x-gz
ip      1036133
2023-07-25T16:43:37+0000        10.7.25.101     192.229.211.108 ocsp.digicert.com       /MFEwTzBNMEswSTAJBgUrDgMCGgUABBS
```

Figure 1 – Zeek run, the logs it produced, and the conn.log / http.log summaries used for Q1 and Q3.

Part 2 – Assignment Questions

1. Connections (conn.log)

How many unique internal IP addresses appear?

> **3 internal hosts**: `10.7.25.101`, `10.7.25.1` and `192.168.68.1`. A 4th private address, `10.7.25.255`, is the subnet *broadcast* address rather than a host. Counting every RFC 1918 address in conn.log gives 4.

Internal IP	What it is (evidence)
10.7.25.101	The **infected Windows client** `DESKTOP-K225LHK` (name from its own NetBIOS/mDNS traffic). It originates every TCP connection in the capture.
10.7.25.1	LAN gateway / DNS server – target of all 169 DNS queries on 53/udp
192.168.68.1	A UPnP device that answered the client's SSDP `M-SEARCH` (2 UDP 1900 replies at 20:02 and 20:17)
10.7.25.255	Broadcast address for NetBIOS (137/138) – not a host

```
zeek-cut id.orig_h id.resp_h < conn.log | tr '\t' '\n' | grep -E '^(10\.|172\.(1[6-9]|2[0-9]|3[01])\.|192\.168\.)' | sort -u
```

Which external IP receives the most connections?

> **2.56.177.122**, with **53 connections**, all TCP/443 TLS. It hosts the IcedID C2 domains `magizanqomo.com` (8) and `magiketchinn.com` (45). Next are 140.99.221.138 (8) and Microsoft/Bing addresses (≤ 4 each).

Which protocols are most commonly used?

Transport	Connections	Zeek `service`	Connections	Bytes (orig+resp)
UDP	**385 (76 %)**	dns*	**329**	54 kB
TCP	121 (24 %)	ssl (TLS)	110	**3.58 MB**
		`-` (unidentified)	61	30 kB
		http	5	1.04 MB
		ntp	1	96 B

> By number of connections: **UDP / DNS** is most common (Windows name resolution). By volume: **TLS (ssl) on TCP/443** dominates with 3.58 MB, followed by **HTTP** at 1.04 MB, which is almost entirely the malware download.

*Zeek's DNS analyzer also parses NetBIOS-NS (137/udp, 129 conns), LLMNR (5355) and mDNS (5353), so these appear as `dns`. The 61 unidentified connections are NetBIOS datagrams (138/udp), SSDP (1900/udp) and **two TCP/443 connections to 165.232.175.216 that are not TLS** (see Q4/Q5).

2. DNS (dns.log)

What domains were queried? dns.log has **36 distinct query names**. That's 33 real DNS names plus NetBIOS names (`WORKGROUP`, `MACBOOKPRO-B348`, upper/lower-case `DESKTOP-K225LHK`). Most are normal Windows/Office background traffic:

Normal: dns.msftncsi.com (18), v10.events.data.microsoft.com (14), settings-win.data.microsoft.com, licensing.mp.microsoft.com, self.events.data.microsoft.com, www.bing.com, ctldl.windowsupdate.com, evoke-windowsservices-tas.msedge.net, officeclient.microsoft.com, clients.config.office.net, ow1.res.office365.com, fp-vs-nocache.azureedge.net, edge.microsoft.com, pti.store.microsoft.com, fe2cr.update.microsoft.com, fe3cr.delivery.mp.microsoft.com, login.live.com, maps.windows.com, ocsp.digicert.com, time.windows.com, storecatalogrevocation.storequality.microsoft.com, ecs.office.com, client.wns.windows.com, plus local names wpad.localdomain (81), localdomain.localdomain, desktop-k225lhk(.local).

Do any domains look suspicious or unusual? Yes. Six names stand out:

Domain	Answer	Queries	Why suspicious
www.sophrologie-yoga.fr	109.234.165.110	1	Unrelated French yoga site, reached right after a 302 from a raw IP. The ≈201 kB HTTPS download (conn.log) is the initial infection file
filtaferamoza.com	128.199.3.164	1	Random, pronounceable, nonsense name; serves the IcedID payload (Q3)
magizanqomo.com	2.56.177.122	7	Random name; IcedID C2 with a self-signed cert
magiketchinn.com	2.56.177.122	**87**	Random name; re-resolved constantly – the beacon target
lohmotarufos.com	140.99.221.138	5	Random name; backup C2 tried from 20:05 when the main C2 stopped answering – every connection reset
flarkonafaero.com	140.99.221.138	5	Same pattern and IP as above

Things that give them away: freshly invented `.com` names with no real-world meaning, several names sharing one IP, a very high query count (87), and the fact that the client goes straight on to talk TLS to them.

```
zeek-cut query answers < dns.log | sort | uniq -c | sort -rn
```

3. HTTP (http.log)

Which websites were visited? Over plaintext HTTP, there were 6 requests to 4 hosts:

Time	Host	URI	Status	resp_mime_types	Body	User-Agent
16:34:56	173.232.146.10	`/`	302 → https://www.sophrologie-yoga.fr/palatial	–	0	Edge 115 (browser)
16:38:09	**filtaferamoza.com** (128.199.3.164)	`/`	**200**	**application/x-gzip**	**1,036,133**	**none (-)**
16:43:37	ocsp.digicert.com	/MFEwTz...	200	application/ocsp-response	471	Microsoft-CryptoAPI
17:49, 17:49, 19:19	ctldl.windowsupdate.com	/.../disallowedcertstl.cab, authrootstl.cab	304	–	0	Microsoft-CryptoAPI

Over HTTPS, ssl.log's `server_name` shows the user also reached **www.sophrologie-yoga.fr**, the C2 domains above, and Microsoft/Bing services.

Was any file downloaded?

> **Yes.** `GET http://filtaferamoza.com/` returned **application/x-gzip, 1,036,133 bytes** (files.log confirms `source=HTTP`, `mime_type=application/x-gzip`, `total_bytes=1036133`).

The request has **no User-Agent**, the URI is just `/`, and there is no filename. This is the IcedID loader fetching its encoded payload. Suricata's ET rules flag this same request as `ET MALWARE Win32/IcedID Requesting Encoded Binary M4`. The other HTTP "files" are a 471-byte OCSP response and `304 Not Modified` replies from Windows Update, all benign.

```
$ jq -c 'select(.host=="filtaferamoza.com") | {host,uri,method,status_code,user_agent,resp_mime_types,response_body_len}' ht
tp.log
{"host":"filtaferamoza.com","uri":"/","method":"GET","status_code":200,"user_agent":null,"resp_mime_types":["application/x-g
zip"],"response_body_len":1036133}
```

4. SSL/TLS (ssl.log, x509.log)

Were any encrypted connections made?

> **Yes – 110 TLS sessions** (93 established, 17 not; 92 TLS 1.2, 1 TLS 1.3). Top SNIs: **magiketchinn.com (45)**, v10.events.data.microsoft.com (13), **magizanqomo.com (8)**, settings-win.data.microsoft.com (5), **flarkonafaero.com (4)**, **lohmotarufos.com (4)**, www.bing.com (4) and **www.sophrologie-yoga.fr (1)**.

Did any certificates look self-signed or unusual?

> **Yes.** The C2 server 2.56.177.122 presented a **self-signed** certificate (subject = issuer).

```
subject     = O=Internet Widgits Pty Ltd, ST=Some-State, C=AU, CN=localhost
issuer      = O=Internet Widgits Pty Ltd, ST=Some-State, C=AU, CN=localhost      (self-signed)
serial      = D4B36C        key = RSA 2048
not_before  = 2023-07-25 13:55:27 UTC     not_after = 2024-07-24 13:55:27 UTC
```

Why this is unusual:

- `Internet Widgits Pty Ltd` / `Some-State` / `AU` are OpenSSL's **default placeholder values**.
- `CN=localhost` does not match the SNI (`magiketchinn.com`).
- The cert was **generated about 2 hours 44 minutes before** the first C2 connection (16:39:12).
- No public CA issued it.

Every other certificate chains to Microsoft Azure / DigiCert CAs. The only other self-signed entries are the genuine DigiCert *root* certificates, which are self-signed by design. Two more TLS anomalies:

- **165.232.175.216:443** – Zeek's analyzer.log records SSL *protocol violations* ("Invalid headers in SSL connection", "Invalid version … 54915"). Port 443 is being used for a **non-TLS custom protocol**.
- **Failed sessions after 20:05** – all 16 TLS attempts to 2.56.177.122 and 140.99.221.138 (lohmotarufos.com / flarkonafaero.com) end in RST (`conn_state RSTR`) with 0 response bytes; no certificate was sent. These are most of the 17 non-established sessions.

```
$ zeek-cut -d ts server_name version established < ssl.log | grep magi | head -12
2023-07-25T16:39:12+0000        magizanqomo.com TLSv12  T
2023-07-25T16:39:15+0000        magizanqomo.com TLSv12  T
2023-07-25T16:39:15+0000        magizanqomo.com TLSv12  T
2023-07-25T16:39:15+0000        magizanqomo.com TLSv12  T
2023-07-25T16:39:22+0000        magiketchinn.com        TLSv12  T
2023-07-25T16:44:15+0000        magiketchinn.com        TLSv12  T
2023-07-25T16:49:16+0000        magiketchinn.com        TLSv12  T
2023-07-25T16:54:18+0000        magiketchinn.com        TLSv12  T
2023-07-25T16:59:20+0000        magiketchinn.com        TLSv12  T
2023-07-25T17:04:21+0000        magiketchinn.com        TLSv12  T
2023-07-25T17:09:23+0000        magiketchinn.com        TLSv12  T
2023-07-25T17:14:25+0000        magiketchinn.com        TLSv12  T
$ zeek-cut -d certificate.subject certificate.issuer certificate.not_valid_before < x509.log | grep Widgits
O=Internet Widgits Pty Ltd,ST=Some-State,C=AU,CN=localhost      O=Internet Widgits Pty Ltd,ST=Some-State,C=AU,CN=localho
st      2023-07-25T13:55:27+0000
$ zeek-cut -d ts id.resp_h id.resp_p service duration orig_bytes resp_bytes conn_state < conn.log | grep 165.232.175.216
2023-07-25T16:39:22+0000        165.232.175.216 443     -       12165.614397    3666    3434    RSTR
2023-07-25T20:02:18+0000        165.232.175.216 443     -       1146.509668     572     340     S1
$ grep -v "^#" analyzer.log | cut -f2,4,9,10,11
violation       SSL     165.232.175.216 443     Invalid headers in SSL connection. Head1: 131, head2: 248, head3: 102
violation       SSL     165.232.175.216 443     Invalid version in TLS connection. Version: 54915
```

Figure 2 – ssl.log shows the 5-minute C2 sessions; x509.log the self-signed "Internet Widgits" cert; conn.log + analyzer.log the 3.4-hour non-TLS session to 165.232.175.216.

5. Behavioral analysis

Signs of beaconing? **Yes – three periodic channels.**

Channel	Evidence from Zeek logs	Interval
TLS to magiketchinn.com / 2.56.177.122:443	45 ssl.log sessions, 16:39:22 → 20:21:46 (41 established up to 20:00:25, then refused); 87 DNS look-ups of the same name	**mean 303.3 s, median 301.7 s, σ = 6.5 s** – a 5-minute timer
165.232.175.216:443 (non-TLS)	One connection lasting **12,165 s (3 h 23 m)** with only 3,666 B up / 3,434 B down, plus a second 1,147 s session; no DNS name	≈17-byte heartbeat every 60 s (seen in packets) – IcedID **BackConnect** (remote access)
C2 fail-over (2.56.177.122 + 140.99.221.138)	From 20:05 the C2 server stops accepting. Every 5 min (20:05, 20:10, 20:16, 20:21) the bot tries **all four** C2 names – magiketchinn, magizanqomo, lohmotarufos, flarkonafaero – ~5 s apart; all 16 attempts fail (RST, `established=F`)	~5 min – same timer, now cycling through a C2 list

Normal periodic Windows traffic (NetBIOS every 120 s, SSDP/LLMNR/mDNS every 900 s) is local-only and expected. The 5-minute TLS beacon to an IP with a fresh self-signed cert is not.

Evidence of data exfiltration? **No large upload.** The host sent 279 kB to the Internet and received 4.36 MB.

- The biggest upload is 36 kB, to Windows Update (fe2cr.update.microsoft.com, 20.62.190.191), which is benign.
- The C2 sessions are lopsided the other way. The first C2 session (16:39:12, magizanqomo.com) uploaded **1,059 B** and **downloaded 1,907,544 B**: IcedID pulling additional modules from the C2 server.

There *is* small-scale data theft. The IcedID HTTP request to filtaferamoza.com carries host-profiling data in its cookie: hostname `DESKTOP-K225LHK`, username `user`, bot ID and OS build `10.0.19045`, decoded in the Wireshark part. The low-volume C2 and BackConnect channels could also carry stolen data that we cannot see because it is encrypted or obfuscated.

`zeek-cut id.orig_h id.resp_h id.resp_p service orig_bytes resp_bytes < conn.log | sort -k5 -rn | head` (uploads) and `sort -k6 -rn` (downloads)

6. Report

Likely compromise scenario. Windows host **10.7.25.101 (DESKTOP-K225LHK, user "user")** was infected with **IcedID (BokBot)**, a banking trojan and malware loader often used as an initial-access foothold for ransomware operators. At 16:34:56 UTC the user's Edge browser visited `http://173.232.146.10/`, which 302-redirected to `https://www.sophrologie-yoga.fr/palatial`. About 201 kB was then downloaded over HTTPS; this was most likely the malicious file the user opened. Three minutes later (16:38:09) the newly running IcedID installer made a User-Agent-less `GET /` to the random domain **filtaferamoza.com (128.199.3.164)**. The request carried a host-profiling cookie, and the server returned a 1,036,133-byte `application/x-gzip` blob, IcedID's encoded payload. From 16:39 onward the bot talked to its C2 server **2.56.177.122** (magizanqomo.com, then magiketchinn.com) over TLS with a self-signed `CN=localhost / Internet Widgits Pty Ltd` certificate created that morning. It first downloaded ≈1.9 MB of follow-up modules and then **beaconed every ~5 minutes for 3.5 hours**. In parallel it opened a long-lived, non-TLS channel on port 443 to **165.232.175.216**, consistent with IcedID's BackConnect/VNC module giving an operator hands-on access. At 20:05 the C2 server stopped accepting connections. On the same 5-minute timer the bot then cycled through its whole C2 list – magiketchinn.com, magizanqomo.com and the backups lohmotarufos.com / flarkonafaero.com (140.99.221.138) – and every attempt was reset until the capture ended at 20:21.

Supporting evidence. conn.log: 53 connections to 2.56.177.122 (most-contacted external IP); a 1.9 MB C2 download; a 12,165-second connection to 165.232.175.216 with no recognized service; 4.36 MB down vs 279 kB up. dns.log: random-looking domains, with 87 look-ups of magiketchinn.com. http.log + files.log: the 1 MB `application/x-gzip` download from filtaferamoza.com with no User-Agent. ssl.log: 45 sessions to magiketchinn.com at a fixed 303-second interval (σ 6.5 s). x509.log: the self-signed C2 certificate with OpenSSL default fields, issued 2 h 44 m before first use. analyzer.log: protocol violations proving the 165.232.175.216 "HTTPS" traffic is not TLS. Recommended response: isolate 10.7.25.101 and reimage it, reset the user's credentials, block the listed domains/IPs at DNS and the firewall, and hunt for the same indicators on other hosts.

Indicators of compromise: 173.232.146.10, www.sophrologie-yoga.fr (109.234.165.110), filtaferamoza.com (128.199.3.164), magizanqomo.com / magiketchinn.com (2.56.177.122), 165.232.175.216:443, lohmotarufos.com / flarkonafaero.com (140.99.221.138), C2 cert serial D4B36C, payload SHA-256 729a9743319f548134a1535291bea0bfdac6cd9a8c4c9ba19ab1b8524d5ebea7.